

Thirteen Days: The Cuban Missile Crisis (1962)

Thomas Jefferson Model United Nations Conference

TechMUN XXXIII



Middle School Single Delegate Crisis Committee

Co-Chairs: Rakshana Damodaran & Samvit Hariharan

Committee Director: Vaneesha Vijayram

Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology

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Esteemed Delegates,

Welcome to the Cuban Missile Crisis (1962) at TechMUN XXVI. It is our pleasure to be your co-chairs and director for this crisis committee! As crisis delegates ourselves, we have experienced the stress and craziness but learned to love it with all our hearts.

With regard to this committee, we want it to be an enjoyable experience for everyone. We will be looking for delegates who bring unique, new ideas to the table and understand the importance of being a diplomatic delegate. We are very excited to hear your debates and discussions about the two pressing issues we face related to the Bay of Pigs Operation and Jupiter Missile Trade, using your particular stance to back up your opinions and solutions.

In regard to the types of delegates we're looking for, we want individuals who can bring creativity to the table and make a real impact, both in their speeches and behind the scenes in the backroom. Leadership matters, but we're more interested in leaders who can inspire collaboration, bring fresh ideas, and ensure their bloc members are heard. This conference is your chance to think outside the box and brainstorm innovative directives that can shape the direction of the committee. Don't be afraid to take calculated risks, explore new approaches, and surprise us. However, no forms of harassment, bullying, or plagiarism will be tolerated.

As your co-chairs and director, we hope to make the committee exciting and something memorable to always hold onto. We are beyond ecstatic to meet you in March! If you have any questions, don't hesitate to contact us at cubanmissilecrisistechmun2026@gmail.com.

Best regards,

Rakshana Damodaran, Samvit Hariharan, and Vaneesha Vijayram

Thirteen Days: The Cuban Missile Crisis (1962)

Topic 1: Operation: Bay of Pigs

Background:

At the height of the Cold War, the world shifts closer to a full-scale nuclear war. Geopolitical tensions rise as a result of the Soviet Union's secret deployment of Soviet nuclear missiles near Cuba. Therefore, leading up to the Cuban Missile Crisis, a thirteen-day confrontation between the United States and the Soviet Union. This put the U.S. in the same immediate threat that the Soviets faced when the U.S. stationed nuclear missiles in Turkey and Italy, close to Soviet territory. These rising tensions were intensified by a pivotal event: the Bay of Pigs invasion.

Prior to the Bay of Pigs Invasion, Cuba was ruled by Fulgencio Batista, a U.S.-backed authoritarian leader whose ruling was marked by widespread corruption, severe economic inequalities, heavy U.S. influence over Cuban land and sugar, and high political repression. In response to Batista's regime, Fidel Castro led the Cuban Revolution, overthrowing Batista in 1959. After gaining power, Castro shifted towards Communism, eliminated political opposition, nationalized institutions, and seized U.S.-owned property without compensation. He also aligned Cuba with the USSR, intensifying tensions with the U.S., which feared having an enemy only ninety miles from its shores.

These tensions culminated in the Bay of Pigs, a CIA-backed attempt to overthrow Fidel Castro using Cuban exiles, planned under Dwight D. Eisenhower and executed by John F. Kennedy. In April 1961, a force of approximately 1400 Cuban exiles, known as the Brigade of 2506 and trained under the CIA, landed at the Bay of Pigs. They fought against Cuban forces for three days, resulting in their loss due to weak U.S. air support and strong Cuban military

resistance. After the invasion, international security advanced, and thousands of suspected opponents were arrested. Fidel Castro gained even more power, declared Cuba socialist, and fully supported the USSR.

Current Situation:

By 1962, the failure of the Bay of Pigs invasion had dramatically reshaped the political and military landscape of the Cold War. Fidel Castro has consolidated control over Cuba, transforming the nation into a firmly socialist state aligned with the Soviet Union. The Bay of Pigs invasion intended to weaken his regime, but instead intensified his distrust with the United States and strengthened his alliance with the Soviet Union. The USSR prime minister, Nikita Khrushchev, secretly deployed nuclear ballistic missiles, nuclear-capable bombers, and Soviet troops to Cuba in order to improve Cuban military protection. U.S. U-2 spy reconnaissance planes discovered the operation, leading up to the thirteen-day confrontation between both nations. President John F. Kennedy and his advisors currently face urgent decisions on how to respond. Military leaders advocate for air strikes or a full-scale invasion, while others argue for diplomatic or economic measures to avoid triggering nuclear war.

Meanwhile, Nikita Khrushchev views the Bay of Pigs as evidence of U.S. aggression and vulnerability. Interpreting the failed mission as both a threat to Cuba and an opportunity to shift the nuclear balance of the U.S. and USSR, the Soviet Union deployed nuclear missiles and troops in Cuba. This strategic move aimed to even the playing field between both global superpowers by deterring U.S. intervention and countering American missiles in Turkey and Italy.

As tensions escalate, the Bay of Pigs invasion remains a central factor driving mistrust, fear, and escalation between the United States, Cuba, and the Soviet Union. The world balances

on the brink of conflict, and the decisions made in the aftermath of the Bay of Pigs will determine whether the crisis ends in negotiation or catastrophe.

Solutions:

To address the escalating tensions caused by the Bay of Pigs invasion and the Soviet missile deployment in Cuba, the United States could pursue peaceful negotiation with the USSR or take other potential measures, but these risks could result in nuclear warfare. One approach is diplomatic negotiation, in which both superpowers agree to de-escalate tensions through mutual agreements, such as the withdrawal of Soviet missiles from Cuba in exchange for U.S. assurances not to invade Cuba. Additionally, the U.S. could initiate a naval quarantine around Cuba to pose strength without direct military confrontation, causing controlled pressure to burden the USSR. Another option is that the U.S. could remove their missiles from Turkey and Italy, but this could take down their opposing power towards the USSR and leave them vulnerable. Ultimately, it is up to you all as U.S. military, intelligence, and diplomatic leaders to determine the most effective way for the United States to resolve their conflict with the USSR while minimizing the risk of nuclear war and preserving U.S. security in the aftermath of the failed Bay of Pigs operation.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can the United States and the Soviet Union peacefully resolve tensions without causing a full-scale nuclear war?
2. What first steps should the U.S. take at the confrontation to avoid any unwanted disputes?
3. Should the U.S. reattempt to overtake Cuba, gain more military support from other nations, or strive for a more peaceful approach?
4. Could the U.S. potentially deploy missiles secretly in other nations similar to the Soviet Union? Or would this be too risky, viewing the situation at hand?
5. Is it fair that the Soviet Union deployed missiles near Cuba because the U.S. placed missiles in Turkey and Italy?
6. What does the U.S. need to be aware of regarding Soviet Union tactics and goals?
7. How can the U.S. utilize their current resources, expertise, and alliances to settle their geopolitical conflicts with Russia?

Topic 2: Jupiter Missile Trade

Background:

Escalating tensions in Europe led to the US putting “Jupiter” nuclear missiles in Italy and Turkey, all in range of key cities in Russia. Jupiter missiles were U.S. Army/Air Force Intermediate-Range Ballistic Missiles (IRBMs) used in the late 1950s and early 1960s, capable of carrying nuclear warheads up to 1,500 miles. To retaliate against this, Russia’s Nikita Khrushchev and Cuba’s Fidel Castro met in July of 1962 to place nuclear missiles in Cuba to further deter a future invasion. This led to the Jupiter missile trade and eventually led to the escalation of the Cold War waged between the US and Russia. With both countries having life-ending missiles aimed at each other, the world was at a standstill. This eventually led to the invasion of Cuba by the US and then the removal of all these missiles from Turkey and Italy by the US as part of an agreement between Russia and the US.

Current Situation:

When Kennedy ran for president in 1960, one of the biggest driving factors behind his campaign was settling the differences between the US and the Soviets. First, this started with getting the US on the same nuclear level as the Russians. The US then started building ICBMs and had around 170 at the start of 1962, with more still growing. They lowered the perception of a “missile gap” between the two powerhouses and made the US a much more feared force. Once Russia, and at the time the Soviets’ First Secretary Nikita Khrushchev, learned of this, they started to fear the US and their military force.

This is what prompted Russia to subsequently place missiles strategically in Cuba. Even though the missiles made by Russia were not accurate nor reliable, the mere threat of having these in close proximity to the US made them a real threat, one that would have to be taken care of immediately. This led to the Americans placing missiles in Turkey and Italy and put the world at a standstill. If the Americans launched first, Russia could easily retaliate by launching their own missiles into the US, and if Russia attacked first, then the US could just as easily do the same.

Solutions:

The question of who should take their weapons out first is a hard one and not one that can be answered easily. For starters, the Soviet Union should not be allowed to use Cuba as a puppet state, but the US also can't place that big of a burden on Turkey, holding all of their nuclear missiles. This has to lead to an agreement being worked out between the two superpowers in a way that benefits them both. The decision is yours. What should happen between the countries so that Russia agrees to the US's deals and removes their weapons, and what does the US need to honor to get that to happen?

Questions to Consider:

- Should the US be able to keep missiles in Turkey and Italy with no consequence?
- If the U.S. removes Jupiter missiles from Turkey, will it encourage the Soviet Union to demand similar concessions elsewhere in the future?
- Does keeping nuclear missiles in Turkey truly increase U.S. security, or does it make NATO allies and the U.S. more vulnerable to a first strike?

- Can a secret missile trade preserve peace without undermining U.S. credibility with allies and the American public if it is later revealed?



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Thirteen Days: The Cuban Missile Crisis (1962) Dossier

Robert F. Kennedy

Robert F. Kennedy is the Attorney General of the US. As the Attorney General, he has a lot of say in what laws are passed and the enforcement of those laws in the US. He is also one of the key backend negotiators for any hostage situations.

Robert McNamara

Robert McNamara is the Secretary of Defense of the United States. As Secretary of Defense, he oversees the entire U.S. military and plays a central role in deciding military strategy, troop movements, and nuclear preparedness.

Dean Rusk

Robert McNamara is the Secretary of Defense of the United States. As Secretary of Defense, he oversees the entire U.S. military and plays a central role in deciding military strategy, troop movements, and nuclear preparedness.

McGeorge Bundy

McGeorge Bundy is the National Security Advisor to the President. As National Security Advisor, he controls the flow of intelligence to the president and helps shape national security decisions.

Maxwell D. Taylor

General Maxwell Taylor is the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. As Chairman, he advises the president on military options and coordinates recommendations from all branches of the armed forces.

Curtis LeMay

Curtis LeMay is the Chief of Staff of the United States Air Force. As Chief of Staff, he controls U.S. strategic air power and strongly advocates for aggressive military action, including air strikes on Cuba.

George W. Anderson Jr

General Maxwell Taylor is the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. As Chairman, he advises the president on military options and coordinates recommendations from all branches of the armed forces.

John A. McCone

John A. McCone is the Director of Central Intelligence. As Director, he oversees the CIA and is responsible for gathering and analyzing intelligence on Soviet missile installations in Cuba.

Adlai Stevenson II

Adlai Stevenson II is the United States Ambassador to the United Nations. As Ambassador, he represents the U.S. in the UN and plays a key role in publicly confronting the Soviet Union and defending U.S. actions before the international community.

Llewellyn Thompson

Llewellyn Thompson is the United States Ambassador to the Soviet Union. As Ambassador, he manages diplomatic relations with Soviet leadership and advises the president on Soviet intentions, making him a key voice in assessing how the USSR may respond to U.S. actions during the crisis.

Paul Nitze – Assistant Secretary of Defense for International Security Affairs

Paul Nitze is responsible for U.S. nuclear strategy, arms control policy, and long-term military planning. As Assistant Secretary, he evaluates how each decision affects the global nuclear balance, escalation risks, and future U.S.–Soviet arms competition, making him highly influential in debates over deterrence and long-term strategy.

Roswell Gilpatric – Deputy Secretary of Defense

Roswell Gilpatric is the second-highest official in the Department of Defense and works closely with both civilian leaders and military commanders. As Deputy Secretary, he serves as a bridge between aggressive military proposals and political realities, shaping which options are realistically presented to the President.

Theodore Sorensen – *Presidential advisor and speechwriter*

Theodore Sorensen is a close advisor to the President and the chief architect of presidential speeches. As Advisor, he shapes how U.S. actions are explained to the public, Congress, and the international community. Thus, influencing legitimacy and public support.

Alexis Johnson – *Deputy Under Secretary of State*

Alexis Johnson manages high-level diplomatic coordination within the State Department. As Deputy Under Secretary, he helps ensure U.S. diplomatic actions are consistent across allies and regions. He manages alliance expectations during the crisis.

C. Douglas Dillon – *Secretary of the Treasury*

Douglas Dillon oversees U.S. financial policy and economic stability. As Treasury Secretary, he evaluates the economic consequences of military action, sanctions, and global market disruption, especially how escalation could affect confidence in the U.S. economy.

Abraham Chayes – *Legal advisor to the State Department*

Abraham Chayes is responsible for ensuring U.S. actions comply with international law. As Legal Advisor, he develops legal justifications for actions such as the naval quarantine and advises on how to frame U.S. policy under the UN Charter.

U. Alexis Johnson – *State Department crisis manager*

U. Alexis Johnson coordinates real-time diplomatic responses across agencies. As Crisis Manager, he oversees implementation of decisions, manages rapid communication, and ensures foreign-policy directives are executed consistently.

Arthur Schlesinger Jr. – *Historian and White House advisor*

Arthur Schlesinger Jr. provides historical and political context to presidential decision-making. As White House Advisor, he emphasizes long-term political consequences and often cautions against rash or irreversible military escalation.

Roger Hilsman – *Assistant Secretary of State for Far Eastern Affairs*

Roger Hilsman oversees U.S. policy in East Asia. As Assistant Secretary, he evaluates how U.S. actions in Cuba affect credibility with Asian allies and adversaries, particularly China, focusing on global precedent rather than regional outcomes alone.

David Ormsby-Gore – *British Ambassador to the U.S. (close U.S. advisory role)*

David Ormsby-Gore represents the United Kingdom and is a trusted personal confidant of the President. As Ambassador, he communicates allied concerns, advises on NATO unity, and helps coordinate British–American positions.

Earle Wheeler – *Army Chief of Staff*

General Earle Wheeler oversees U.S. Army readiness and ground-force planning. As Army Chief, he advises on invasion scenarios, troop deployments, and the feasibility of occupying Cuba if military escalation is approved.

Wallace Greene Jr. – *Commandant of the Marine Corps*

General Wallace Greene Jr. commands the U.S. Marine Corps. As Commandant, he is responsible for amphibious assault planning and Marine readiness, making him central to any proposal involving a direct landing or invasion.

Joseph Califano – *Defense Department aide*

Joseph Califano serves as a senior civilian advisor within the Department of Defense. As Defense Aide, he assists with policy coordination, drafts recommendations, and helps shape how defense information is shown to senior leadership.

Edwin Martin – *Assistant Secretary of State for Inter-American Affairs*

Edwin Martin oversees U.S. relations with Latin America. As Assistant Secretary, he evaluates how U.S. actions toward Cuba impact hemispheric alliances, regional stability and diplomatic support.

Richard Helms – *Deputy Director of the CIA*

Richard Helms manages day-to-day CIA operations. As Deputy Director, he oversees intelligence collection, covert activities, and analysis related to Soviet and Cuban actions. Thus, framing the intelligence picture used for decision-making.

Marshall Carter – *Deputy Director of Central Intelligence*

Marshall Carter assists in planning intelligence assessments across agencies. As Deputy Director, he ensures intelligence from military and civilian sources is implemented, accurate, and clearly communicated to policymakers.

George Ball – *Under Secretary of State*

George Ball is a senior diplomatic official who is known for his cautious approach to military escalation. As Under Secretary, he always emphasizes diplomatic solutions and warns of unforeseen political and international consequences.

Elbridge Durbrow – *State Department official*

Elbridge Durbrow advises on diplomatic strategy and coordination internally. As State Department official, he supports policy planning, communication between different agencies, and negotiations with allies and adversaries.

Henry Cabot Lodge Jr. – *Former UN Ambassador, consulted during crisis*

Henry Cabot Lodge Jr. is consulted for his extensive diplomatic experience. As former Ambassador, he advises on international perception, alliance politics, and how U.S. actions will be received at the United Nations.